UK: Path to EU re-entry faces formidable obstacles

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【メール原文】

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Prime Minister Andy Burnham will use the 20 November UK-EU summit to launch a debate on Britain’s future relationship with the EU, including the possibility of rejoining the bloc.
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Burnham’s willingness to restore free movement of labour with the EU represents a fundamental break with Labour’s post-Brexit position, and his cabinet remains deeply divided on Brexit-related issues.
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Burnham is unlikely to commit Labour to rejoining the EU before testing public and parliamentary support for the idea, making a second referendum likely if Burnham pursues full EU membership as opposed to customs union or single market membership.

Burnham is dramatically reviving the Brexit debate. In the ten years since the UK voted to leave the EU, the Labour Party has been reluctant to discuss Brexit. As recently as May, during his Makerfield by-election, Andy Burnham said reopening Brexit arguments was “the last thing we should do right now.” Now as prime minister, Burnham is calling for a new debate over the options, including whether the UK should “go all the way” and rejoin the 27-member bloc.

Burnham is open to restoring free movement of workers with the EU—a politically untouchable issue for Labour since the 2016 Brexit referendum. He is also questioning other red lines in the party’s 2024 election manifesto: staying out of the single market and customs union (although those positions will remain in place until the next general election). Burnham does not intend to recommend the UK joins the euro or the Schengen passport-free zone; his allies are confident the EU would grant the UK opt-outs from both. Eurasia Group also assesses that outcome as likely.

Burnham’s openness to free movement was a signal to Brussels. Burnham sought to provide reassurance that he would not try to cherry-pick EU treaties, as the UK has done in the past. Nonetheless, some Labour figures suspect Labour will end up with a bespoke deal—although there would be little appetite for that in the EU.

The prime minister’s intervention surprised not only Whitehall, which is struggling to respond, but also his own cabinet. Some cabinet members representing leave-voting constituencies in the 2016

referendum are wary about reopening a divisive debate. They fear raising the issue of free movement will play into the hands of Nigel Farage's Reform UK and the Conservatives given public concern about immigration. Doubters about a rejoin push include Louise Haigh, Burnham's de facto deputy; Chancellor John Healey; Home Secretary Shabana Mahmood; Business Secretary Jonathan Reynolds; Health Secretary Yvette Cooper; Education Secretary Lucy Powell; Culture Secretary Lisa Nandy; and Chief Whip Anneliese Midgley.

Ironically, today's cabinet is less pro-European than under Keir Starmer. Burnham removed Europhiles including Rachel Reeves, David Lammy, Darren Jones, Hilary Benn, Peter Kyle, and Nick Thomas-Symonds. Insiders believe a narrow cabinet majority favors rejoining the EU but admit the issue is deeply divisive. Burnham is driving the process himself. He is already trying to enforce collective responsibility and has told ministers not to "advocate for specific options or opine on the likely outcome of the process."

Why has Burnham shifted course? There are several theories in his party. "He wants to rejoin and is going for it," one adviser said. Another said Burnham was "aiming high" and testing the water to see how far public opinion has changed. Although opinion polls show a majority favor re-entry, people are less certain about the specific terms. They broadly oppose euro and Schengen membership. Some Labour MPs are skeptical that Burnham is fully committed. They believe his main goal may be to woo pro-European Liberal Democrat and Green voters, and their MPs, in the event of a hung parliament after the next election.

The prime minister will attend his first meeting of the 50-member European Political Community in Dublin on 12 November before setting out his options around the time of a UK-EU summit in Brussels on 20 November. As neither side will want a failure, this meeting is set to approve the reset begun under Starmer, including an agreement on the frictionless movement of food, animals and plants; emissions trading; and a youth mobility scheme. The UK may allow about 80,000 EU students a year to pay UK rather than overseas tuition fees if, in return, the EU allows Britain to join its protectionist Made in Europe scheme. To prevent a collapse, some tricky issues may be deferred until next year.

Several different scenarios could lead to a new referendum on EU membership. In theory, Burnham could claim a mandate if Labour vowed to rejoin the bloc in its next manifesto, though some party figures favor single market membership or a vaguer pledge to negotiate the best deal. In practice, Eurasia Group believes that demands for a new referendum to overturn the 2016 result would force him to concede one. The EU would welcome a referendum, as it would make it harder for a future Reform or Tory government to reverse re-entry. Another scenario is that Burnham argues that resolving Britain's place in Europe would boost economic growth and uses that case as the reason for calling an election before the scheduled 2029 date. However, right-wing parties would not allow Labour to run a single-issue campaign on Europe and, with the media's help, would also frame the contest as a "tax and spending" election.

Happy to discuss,

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